



Gamification of The Curriculum: From Academic Words to Virtual Worlds in Civilization and Literature Pedagogy

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Abstract ;

This study argues for integrating commercial video games into Algerian higher education to revitalize civilization and literature pedagogy by shifting learners from passive reception to active, immersive inquiry. Grounded in Huizinga's Homo Ludens and Csikszentmihalyi's flow theory, it frames game-based learning as a pathway to optimal engagement through clear goals, feedback, balanced challenge-skill, and deep immersion articulated in the Game Flow model. Drawing on Assassin's Creed: Origins and BioShock Infinite, it demonstrates how historically and narratively robust titles can function as authentic, multimodal learning environments aligned to curricular aims. Given Generation Z's pervasive gaming habits in Algeria, these tools can bridge cultural content with contemporary media fluency while addressing boredom and anxiety common in traditional lectures. The work situates promise alongside practical constraints in local institutions and calls for empirical trials, including surveys and classroom implementations, to assess learning outcomes, equity, and feasibility across contexts.

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1. Introduction:

Algeria's educational system has long relied on conventional teaching methods that emphasize memorization and passive learning. Traditional approaches to teaching civilization and literature often present historical events and literary works as static information to be absorbed rather than dynamic narratives to be explored and understood. Students frequently struggle to connect with ancient civilizations or classical literature when these subjects are presented through textbooks and lectures alone. The disconnect between contemporary digital culture and traditional academic content creates additional barriers to engagement, particularly among younger generations who have grown up with interactive media.

As an over a decade educator whose career is mostly spent in teaching these two widely dreaded fields of study (Civilization and Literature), I have observed that the mood of the majority of students during the lecture ranges between the two extremes of boredom and anxiety. On one hand, they feel bored due to the proclaimed unengaging material presented, and this is more prominent among the ENS (École Normale Supérieure) students as their orientation is more biased generally towards pedagogy, didactics, and the skills. According to them, these academic fields are mostly what they would need in teaching. On the other, they feel anxious

when they delve into the overwhelming complex and philosophical content of some heavy topics in these two fields of study.

The Algerian Ministry of Education has recognized these challenges and has been gradually implementing reforms aimed at modernizing pedagogical approaches. However, the transition from teacher-centred to student-centred learning that suits today's generation requires innovative tools and methodologies that can bridge the gap between traditional academic content and contemporary learning preferences. Interactive gaming represents one such bridge, offering the potential to transform how students engage with complex historical and literary materials.

1. Play, Flow Theory, and Game-Based Learning: A Synthesis

Over the past 20 years, a significant body of research that centred around the idea that the activity of "play", especially interactive gaming or video games, can be a transformational force in education helped to some extent remove the stigma around such activity. Researchers like James P. Gee (2007), Mark Prensky (2001), and Richard Van Eck (2006), argued that through the increased immersion, enjoyment, and engagement, video games has become progressively popular in education.

The ever-growing body of literature that infuse the element of "play" and its

contemporary manifestation, video games, within the field of education keeps highlighting more and more educational advantages for such combination. For Andrew Burn and David Buckingham (2007), video games as rich multimodal texts that combine different communicative modes would offer unlimited potential for educational possibilities especially if we get the students themselves involved in the process of game design; For Caroline Pelletier (2009), it is the ability to increase deep learning and provide immediate feedback that make them invaluable; fostering critical thinking and cognitive skills through experiential learning (Hubert-Wallander, Green, & Bavelier, 2010), and potential improvement in student attentional and visual perception skills (Green & Bavelier, 2006) just to name a few. Moreover, studies suggest that video games can expand students' conceptions of literacy, boost engagement, and empower learners in ways that redistribute classroom agency and reshape teacher–student relationship dynamics (Nash & Brady, 2022).

Video gaming industry is here to stay as it is becoming more and more immersive and realistic; Hence, it is attracting more and more people to its fanbase. Today, our Algerian young adults, i.e. our students in higher education are being progressively more involved with the world of gaming. Yet, we as educators are falling behind when it comes to adapting to this new

reality in comparison with both our students and educators around the world. Being an educator myself and a hardcore gamer allows me, I would presume, to have a dual vantage point in observing the matter from both angles. There is certainly a significant potential to this digital interactive platform. The most glaring issue, however, is that the impediments between the Algerian educational environment and video games are substantial. Still, one must begin somewhere.

2. Theoretical Foundations: From Huizinga's Homo Ludens to Gen-Z Digital Natives

In order to associate “gaming” with the process of education, one must first establish a solid and relevant definition of the fundamental action we undertake during video-games sessions, i.e. “playing”.

The act of playing is usually associated with two main elements, children and entertainment. According to Oxford, it is simply “*any spontaneous or organized activity that provides enjoyment, entertainment, amusement, or diversion. Play in childhood is essential to enable holistic development.*” (Oxford, n.d.). However, according to Sutton-Smith, play in its fundamental core is more complex than that. It is one of the most ambiguous concepts to deal with despite our familiarity with it during our childhood. It

defies singular definition, but it can be understood through the seven distinct “rhetorics” or ideological frameworks of Fate, Power, Communal Identity, Frivolity, Progress, the Imaginary, and the Self (2001).

When it comes to education, Jean Piaget viewed play as fundamental to cognitive development, conceptualizing it as active learning through which children explore, experiment, and construct understanding of their world. In Piagetian theory, play serves as a mechanism for assimilation (fitting new experiences into existing mental structures) and accommodation (modifying structures to incorporate new experiences) (2023).

Lev Vygotsky positioned play within his sociocultural theory, emphasizing its role in the Zone of Proximal Development (ZPD)—the space between what a child can do independently and what they can achieve with guidance. For him, play creates opportunities for children to operate above their average age, above their daily behaviour because in play it is as though he was “a head taller than himself.” (NSW, n.d.)

Despite being perhaps one of the most fringe definitions or approaches to the element of “play”, Johan Huizinga’s identification rung the truest for me when it is subjected to today’s global popular culture. In his renowned book, *Homo*

Ludens (1980), he identifies the element of play as:

a free activity standing quite consciously outside “ordinary” life as being “not serious,” but at the same time absorbing the player intensely and utterly. It is an activity connected with no material interest, and no profit can be gained by it. It proceeds within its own proper boundaries of time and space according to fixed rules and in an orderly manner. It promotes the formation of social groupings which tend to surround themselves with secrecy and to stress their difference from the common world by disguise or other means (1980, p. 13)

Accordingly, play can be any activity that is not necessary, or at least not directly, for one’s survival but in the same time represents a passion that would consume him/her intensely for no apparent materialistic compensation. When it comes to survival, he who engages in an extracurricular activity that is considered by him as fundamental to his existence can be defined as a playing man. For the human society, farming is a fundamental and serious activity but gardening can be considered as an act of play despite being fundamental for that individual’s existence. This does not, however, diminishes the importance of play especially when it comes to culture because, for Huizinga, a certain play-factor or another was enormously active along the cultural process in which many fundamental forms of social life were produced. He discussed

further this point arguing that pure play is the primordial soil from which art and culture has originated:

The spirit of playfulness is, as a social impulse, older than culture itself and pervades all life like a veritable ferment. Rituals grew up in sacred play; poetry was born in play and nourished on play; music and dancing were pure play. Wisdom and philosophy found expression in words and forms derived from religious contests. The rules of warfare, the conventions of noble living were built up on play-patterns. We have to conclude, therefore, that civilization is, in its earliest phases at least, played. It does not come from play like a babe detaching itself from the womb: it arises in and as play, and never leaves it (Huizinga, 1980, p. 173).

Huizinga understood civilisation in itself as a whole is the culmination of play. He positions such activity and its patterns in the heart of all what we do intellectually whether it is religion, art, philosophy, warfare, or nobility, ...etc. For him, play did not only pervade human culture, it rises with it and within it which means humanity, through culture, never stopped “playing”.

In Huizinga’s theory, *Homo Ludens* refers to the idea that play is a primary and essential activity of human beings, as fundamental as reasoning (*Homo Sapiens*) or fabricating tools (*Homo Faber*), and this is why he named his book as such. This individual whom Huizinga defines as the

Homo-Ludens or in other words as the “player man” seems to be quite similar to our artists, actors, athletes, influencers, etc. except in the two elements of unseriousness of play and its connection to materialistic gain. Social networks like TikTok, Instagram, and Facebook are platforms that represent a source of income, endorsements, and market place for these Homo-Ludens, and therefore the activity of play became as serious as it can be for them.

If we draw parallels between Huizinga’s approach to play and today’s generation, we can definitely observe matching consistency and compatibility between the two. Our students generally belong to what is referred to as Generation Z. The latter includes all those born approximately between the mid-1990s and early-2010s. They are the first generation to grow up with the internet, smartphones, and social media as a constant part of life, giving them a reputation as “digital natives”. They were shaped by events like the Great Recession, the COVID-19 pandemic, and rapid technological change. (Eldridge, 2025).

They are above all perhaps the first pure generation of gamers. An overwhelming 87-90% of Gen Z play video games regularly, making them the most gaming-engaged generation in history (Thakur, 2025). 90% of them even consider themselves game enthusiasts who spent hours per day engaged in playing (Knezovic, 2025).

Unlike artists, actors, athletes, or influencers, Gen Z are the real pure Homo Ludens of our time because they are absorbed by playing “intensely and utterly” for no materialistic interest whatsoever. Huizinga’s spirit of playfulness is the socio-cultural impulse of this generation, and gaming is their go-to choice of entertainment just as TV used to be for prior generation of millennials if not even more.

Video games, which is the latest manifestation of play, came to formulate the peak of popular culture nowadays due to its fantastic highly imaginative worlds, level of entertainment, and most importantly its unmatched ability to immerse their audience through involving them even in the narrative creation process. In video games based on storytelling, the passive reader (novels and comics) and viewer (films and series), becomes the active or rather interactive player who, to some degree, controls the actions, decisions, and fates of the protagonist(s) and perhaps even the other characters of the narrative too. Thus, a “playing student” would become immersed and be able to relive the narrative of the academic materials with all its details rather than the old one dimensionality of the same materials during the lecture.

3. Immersion, Agency, and Multimodality in Contemporary Video Games

Gaming is not a 21st century breakthrough as long before video games were a thing, it was recognized that play was essential, for not only learning but all our other intellectual and cultural activities like we have seen with Huizinga. However, whether for the better or worse, video games have become the dominant form of play; they have become an everyday reality.

As of 2025, Algeria has an estimated 6.43 million active gamers across all platforms (mobile, PC, and console), and it keeps increasing (Statista, 2025). This is well within the range of the global trend. The huge proliferation and popularity of gaming is due to its ongoing innovation and technological development. Currently, significant improvements in games’ realism have increased the immersive quality of gaming experiences, rendering them especially appealing to the youth demographic.

In addition to their hyperphotorealism, video games offer a significant advantage over other educational media by providing a holistic and immersive experience. Unlike traditional media, where learners are passive recipients of information, video games engage players as active participants. Rather than merely consuming audio-visual content about World War II, for example, players become part of the conflict itself, fully immersing their senses in events that were previously accessed through static, often tedious,

printed or audio-visual materials. Through gaming, players assume the role of the protagonist they once read about in novels, gaining control over the narrative's progression—deciding who lives and dies. This active involvement fosters a deeper emotional connection and allows players to personally experience the dilemmas and perspectives that the original author intended to convey. In essence, games function as virtual novels and time machines, enabling players to step into the shoes of larger-than-life characters and forgotten heroes of war. They serve as recursive, lucid dreams of complex philosophies, monumental events, and intricate narratives.

4. Csikszentmihalyi's Flow Model in Classroom Engagement:

The integration of video games into formal educational settings has evolved significantly from early experimental applications to sophisticated pedagogical strategies grounded in learning theories (Wouters, Van Nimwegen, Van Oostendorp, & Van Der Spek, 2013, p. 249). Among the theoretical frameworks supporting game-based learning, Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi's flow theory has emerged as particularly relevant for understanding optimal educational experiences (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990).

The concept of flow state has captured the attention of researchers, educators, and practitioners across diverse fields since

Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi first described this phenomenon of optimal human experience in the 1970s. Flow represents a psychological state where individuals become completely absorbed in an activity, experiencing deep engagement, intrinsic motivation, and enhanced performance (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990, p. 4). This state of consciousness, often described as "being in the zone," has been documented across cultures, ages, and activities, from athletes achieving peak performance to artists lost in creative expression, and from surgeons performing complex operations to students deeply engaged in learning.

Csikszentmihalyi's theoretical construct of flow state exhibits substantial similarity with Huizinga's philosophical understanding of play, as both frameworks encompass psychological states marked by complete immersion, perceptual alterations in temporal and spatial dimensions, and elevated performance capabilities. Given these theoretical parallels, it is only reasonable to hypothesize that flow states may be more effectively induced through ludic activities, specifically through the medium of video gaming.

Researchers have moved on from whether gaming is beneficial or not to seeking to understand why certain gaming experiences produce superior learning outcomes. Transferring students from a state of boredom or anxiety into being "*in the zone*" is the ultimate goal here which cannot be achieved unless we take video

gaming as a serious cultural, academic, and educational activity.

Sweetser and Wyeth (2005) undertook an extensive analysis of literature concerning the usability and user experience within the context of video games, in order to delineate the principal elements to such superior outcome. They concluded that enjoyment is a key requirement for achieving the best possible outcome from the activity. Their findings identified eight fundamental elements—namely concentration, challenge, skills, control, clear goals, feedback, immersion, and social interaction—as critical to the experience of enjoyment in gaming. Furthermore, Sweetser and Wyeth observed a notable convergence between these elements and those associated with Csikszentmihalyi's (1990) flow theory, and consequently established a direct correspondence between their player enjoyment components and flow elements, as presented in Table I. This mapping ultimately constituted the foundation of their evaluative framework for player enjoyment, referred to as the Game Flow model. (2005, p. 3)

Table I. Mapping the Elements from Games Literature to the Elements of Flow

Game Flow	Flow
The Game	A task that can be completed
Concentration	Ability to concentrate on the task
Challenge/Player Skills	Perceived skills should match challenges and both must exceed a certain threshold
Control	Allowed to exercise a sense of control over actions
Clear Goals	The task has clear goals
Feedback	The task provides immediate feedback
Immersion	Deep but effortless involvement, reduced concern for self and sense of time
Social Interaction	No corresponding element of flow

Source: Sweetser & Wyeth, 2010, p.10

5. Walking Through Time: Assassin's Creed as a Gateway to Flow-Based Historical Learning

Assassin's Creed (AC): Origins was launched at a high-profile event held at the British Museum in September 2017. This occasion marked the tenth anniversary of the Assassin's Creed series, and Ubisoft commemorated it with an extensive celebration that brought together influencers from around the globe, as well as members of the media and select academics (Poiron, 2021, p. 79). Another partnership was sealed between Ubisoft and the British Library in order to use Assassin's Creed (AC): Origins digital representation of Alexander the Great's

tomb in their physical recreation of his sarcophagus (Maguid, 2022).

The scale of 2017 event and the British Library collaboration underscore the significance of the franchise, which began in 2007 with the release of the original Assassin's Creed game set during the Crusades in Palestine. Since that inaugural title, the series has expanded to include twelve games, each situated in distinct historical periods ranging from the Peloponnesian War to the Renaissance and the Victorian era. Since the very first game "Making history everyone's playground" was Ubisoft's motto and signature for that franchise (Reparaz, 2018), and to get recognition by iconic cultural and historical institutions like The British Museum and Library is the recognition this franchise deserves for painstakingly recreating and visualizing the most monumental eras in human history.

Perhaps the main reason for selecting Assassin's Creed franchise and the first instalment of the trilogy *Origins* (2017) is not just their collaboration with the academic institutions but their zeal when it comes to recreating the worlds of their games. Ubisoft Studios hired, for example, Evelyne Ferron, an ancient history professor from Sherbrooke University as a part of a team of historians and Egyptologists who consulted on the game's historical accuracy and authenticity during its four-year development. Ferron provided lectures, research, and seminars for

designers on ancient Egypt's daily life, architecture, culture, animals, and trade routes, directly influencing design choices and correcting cultural inaccuracies. Her input even led to modifications of certain scenes to reflect correct Egyptian mentality and practices (Ore, 2017). The same goes for the second and third instalment of the latest iconic trilogy by the franchise, Assassin's Creed Odyssey (2018) and, Assassin's Creed Valhalla (2020).

Many of the historians and consultants involved in *Origins* also contributed expertise to ensure the reconstructions of Odyssey's world were authentic and grounded in recent academic research. Academics and museum professionals reviewed details of clothing, architecture, and social practices, often helping the team navigate areas of historical ambiguity (Politopoulos, Mol, Boom, & Ariese, 2019).

Assassin's Creed Valhalla (2020) involved a permanent team of experts from Ubisoft's own Research Unit, as well as external historical consultants. These included historians like Thierry Noël and Professor Ryan Lavelle (University of Winchester), whose expertise covered Viking history, topography, daily life, and regional differences in Britain and Scandinavia. The consultants provided written reports, led field trips, visited museums and archaeological sites, and advised on everything from Norse fighting techniques to bread recipes to fundamental questions

about cultural and political life (Cowen, 2021)

Assassin's Creed Origins represents an exemplary case of commercial video game design that naturally facilitates flow experiences in educational contexts. The game's meticulous attention to historical detail creates an authentic learning environment where students can explore ancient Egyptian civilization through direct experiential engagement rather than passive consumption of textbook information.

The game achieves clear goals through its quest structure, where each mission provides specific objectives such as "explore the Great Library of Alexandria" or "investigate religious practices in ancient Memphis." These goals align directly with curriculum objectives for civilization studies while maintaining the engaging narrative framework that motivates continued exploration.

Immediate feedback occurs through multiple channels: visual feedback as students discover historically accurate architectural details, auditory feedback through period-appropriate music and ambient sounds, and narrative feedback through interactions with historically-informed non-player characters. Research by Politopoulos et al. (2019) demonstrates that students using *Assassin's Creed Origins* showed improved recall of historical facts and enhanced

understanding of cultural contexts compared to traditional instruction methods (2019).

The challenge-skill balance is particularly well-managed through the game's ranging from easy to very hard difficulty modes, which adjusts combat elements in order to suit every student's level of skills. Ultimately, we can avoid making the student bored due to the lack of challenge or anxious because he feels overwhelmed. The student will get into the flow state in which he will enjoy the experience and learn in the same time.

The game facilitates loss of self-consciousness and time transformation through its immersive recreation of ancient Egyptian environments. Students report becoming so absorbed in virtual exploration that they lose awareness of their physical surroundings and spend significantly more time than anticipated investigating historical sites and cultural practices (Casey, 2021)

6. Beyond the Text: Deep Literary Learning Through BioShock Infinite

The realm of video games offers a plethora of great franchises like *The Witcher Trilogy*, *Red Dead Redemption 1&2*, and *BioShock Trilogy*. Unlike *Assassin's Creed* franchise which is based mainly on a spinoff of historical contexts and chronicles, these games are more oriented

towards exploring different layers of narratives, character development, specific philosophical themes, and political critiques.

The Witcher 3 (2015), BioShock Infinite, and Red Dead Redemption 2 are one of the most iconic releases of all time. However, while praised for narrative complexity, The Witcher 3 and Red Dead Redemption 2 present flow disruption through its fragmented storytelling structure. Contemporary research on player engagement in open-world narratives demonstrates that the game's extensive side quest system creates "attention diffusion" that prevents sustained analytical focus. Students encounter difficulty maintaining interpretive momentum across the game's sprawling narrative structure, with meaningful thematic connections often separated by dozens of hours of gameplay (Vickery & Wyeth, 2023)

As for BioShock Infinite, it actually offers sophisticated narrative structures and thematic content that align closely with traditional literature education objectives while providing interactive engagement that can facilitate flow state experiences. The game's exploration of themes including American exceptionalism, religious extremism, social inequality, and personal identity provides rich material for literary analysis and critical thinking development.

Clear goals in literature education contexts emerge through the game's mystery-driven narrative structure. Students must piece together story elements, analyze character motivations, and interpret symbolic content to understand the game's complex themes. These objectives parallel traditional literary analysis while providing immediate, experiential engagement with narrative elements.

The game provides immediate feedback through its reactive narrative system, where player choices influence story development and character relationships. This interactivity allows students to experience firsthand how different interpretive approaches lead to different understanding of narrative meaning, making abstract literary concepts concrete and experientially accessible.

Challenge-skill balance is maintained through the game's layered narrative structure, which provides surface-level story engagement for less experienced students while offering deep symbolic and thematic content for advanced analysis. Students can engage with the material at their current skill level while being challenged to develop more sophisticated interpretive abilities.

The multisensory elements including detailed visual environments, compelling voice acting, and atmospheric music create immersive experiences that facilitate deep emotional engagement with literary

themes. This emotional connection enhances memory formation and motivates continued analysis and discussion.

Conclusion:

The integration of video games into the Algerian curriculum for civilization and literature holds significant promise for regaining student engagement, deepening their learning, and bridging the persistent gap between academic content and digital-age preferences. Drawing from established theoretical frameworks, such as Huizinga's concept of play, Csikszentmihalyi's flow theory, and the GameFlow model, this approach repositions students as active, motivated participants rather than passive recipients in the classroom. Title selections such as *Assassin's Creed: Origins* and *BioShock Infinite* not only demonstrate historical and literary sophistication but also offer authentic, immersive experiences validated by collaborations with professional historians and cultural institutions.

However, while this pedagogical step is grounded in both a robust body of global research and emerging positive attitude shift among Algerian educators and students, successful adoption is neither being systematic nor without challenges. Notably, the promise of greater immersion and individualized learning must be balanced against a realistic assessment of technical barriers that may occur during any attempt of implementation. For

example, disparities in student access to capable hardware, such as modern computers or gaming consoles, and reliable internet may deepen existing educational inequalities, particularly for students from rural or under-resourced backgrounds. Additionally, the variability in digital literacy among both students and faculty poses another layer of complexity, potentially impeding effective participation and classroom management. It is critical, therefore, to address these "digital gaps" through institutional initiatives that guarantee sufficient resources, technical support, and educator training before large-scale curricular integration.

Despite these potential obstacles, the next planned research phase, which includes classroom experimentation and broad-based student surveys, will directly investigate both the pedagogical effectiveness of game-based learning and the practical realities of implementing such innovations within the Algerian ENS educational contexts. These experimental interventions seek not only to empirically validate the theorized benefits of video games for learning but also to extract and address the range of technical and infrastructural limitations encountered by real students.

There is a hope that this work establishes the intellectual and practical spirit and motivation for rethinking humanities education in Algeria by aligning with the lived realities, needs, and aspirations of

Generation Z. Yet, a genuinely transformative and inclusive adoption of educational gaming will require careful navigation of technical challenges, institutional commitment, and ongoing research. The initial steps are already underway, and the outcomes of direct implementation and student feedback will

be vital in shaping scalable, culturally relevant frameworks for the future of digital pedagogy in Algerian higher education.

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